recent centuries. What has been noted for sure is the distinct phase of urbanization and demographic transition whereby natural growth rates—the difference between birth and death rates—tend to increase and place pressure on available agricultural land leading to a movement away from villages. For many countries in western and southern Europe, this movement took place in the cities and settlements in the Americas and colonies around the world. As these societies have completed their demographic transitions and face low or even negative natural growth rates, they tend to attract immigrants, especially in the low-end jobs vacated by the natives. Wage differentials form an important part of this narrative as they signal opportunities for people to move. Thus, relatively more developed countries and major cities tend to have net immigration or inmigration rather than net emigration or outmigration as they offer higher wages.

The historical experience of migration in India follows some of these broad patterns, but with interesting twists. As the previous chapters have documented, migration has been highly circulatory and clustered in nature. Certain parts of India have experienced mass migration histories for centuries while other regions have been bypassed or have only recently witnessed signs of rising spatial mobility. Science and technology mattered in terms of the railways, steamboats and communications services that propelled spatial mobility in the late 19th century. Mobility in India—internal and international—also closely followed the logic of globalization, rising in the late 19th and early 20th century and then again towards the end of the 20th century. In this, the colonial experience was critical in shaping the initial surge in outmigration and the choice of destinations, with persistent legacies. Patterns of migration broadly followed economic development, with the more developed and fast-growing states or provinces experiencing net inmigration rather than outmigration.[6]

Democracy in independent India continued the earlier ideas of unrestricted spatial movement, with a few caveats, in stark contrast to communist China which regulated rural–urban migration through an internal permit system known as the *hukou*. And yet, over the past four